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TOPIC: *Using Cyber Operations to Disrupt Human Trafficking Networks*

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This memo examines how transnational human trafficking networks are increasingly using digital tools and cyber-enabled systems to expand operations, evade detection, and generate revenue. It explains how trafficking groups rely on encrypted platforms, online recruitment, and cryptocurrency-based financial systems, while current U.S. intelligence efforts are fragmented across cyber, financial, and criminal domains.

Although agencies collect valuable intelligence, coordination is often limited and reactive. This affects the U.S. ability to identify and disrupt trafficking networks early, particularly as these networks integrate with cyber fraud and transnational crime. The Intelligence Community does not consistently treat human trafficking as a cyber-enabled national security threat, further limiting strategic prioritization and resource alignment.

This memo recommends three actions: (1) designate cyber-enabled human trafficking as a priority for the Intelligence Community, (2) improve the integration of Cyber, Financial, and Trafficking Intelligence, and (3) strengthen Intelligence Support for Financial and Overseas Network Disruption.

These steps would improve intelligence coordination, strengthen early detection, and enable more proactive disruption of trafficking networks.

BACKGROUND

Human trafficking networks are increasingly digital and transnational. Rather than operating through localized, physical systems, traffickers now rely on online platforms, social media, encrypted messaging applications, online advertisements, and digital payment systems to identify, recruit, and exploit victims across borders, coordinate operations, and move illicit profits.

Recent enforcement actions show a growing link between human trafficking and cyber-enabled financial crime. The U.S. Department of Justice recently targeted scam compounds in Southeast Asia that combine forced labor with large-scale online fraud. These operations rely on trafficked individuals who are forced to run fraudulent investment schemes and other online scams. Authorities disrupted digital infrastructure, seized hundreds of websites, and restrained hundreds of millions of dollars linked to these networks. Countries such as Cambodia, Laos, and Myanmar have become central locations for these large-scale operations, which are often linked to transnational organized crime groups.

Financial systems used by trafficking networks have also become more complex and difficult to trace. The U.S. Department of the Treasury has identified the use of cryptocurrency, shell companies, and cross-border financial transfers to hide illegal flows. Its 2026 National Money

Laundering Risk Assessment shows that professional laundering networks support criminal organizations involved in human trafficking, fraud, and other illicit activities.

Despite these developments, U.S. government responses remain fragmented. Law enforcement agencies focus on victim identification and prosecution, financial regulators target illicit transactions, and intelligence agencies track transnational threats. Within the Intelligence Community, agencies such as the National Security Agency, the Central Intelligence Agency, and the Treasury collect relevant intelligence, but their efforts lack integration.

ANALYSIS

1. Cyber Tools Are Central to Modern Trafficking Operations

Digital tools are crucial for human trafficking networks. Online platforms allow traffickers to recruit victims across borders at low cost and scale operations quickly. Encrypted messaging applications reduce the risk of detection, while digital payment systems enable fast and difficult-to-trace financial transactions.

Trafficking with cyber fraud has increased the scale and complexity of the threat. Scam centers using trafficked labor show how physical exploitation and digital crime now operate within the same networks. This integration makes trafficking organizations more profitable, adaptable, and resilient. As a result, cyber-enabled trafficking is expanding faster than current intelligence responses.

2. Intelligence Efforts Remain Fragmented and Reactive

The Intelligence Community has strong capabilities in cyber operations, financial intelligence, and transnational threat analysis. However, these capabilities are not integrated to address trafficking networks as a unified problem.

Cyber intelligence efforts often prioritize state actors and major cybercriminal groups, while trafficking is largely treated as a law enforcement issue. Financial intelligence can identify suspicious transactions, but it is not always linked to trafficking indicators. At the same time, foreign intelligence collection does not prioritize trafficking networks unless they relate to broader national security concerns.

This fragmentation creates gaps in connecting digital communications, financial flows, and operational activity. As a result, intelligence remains siloed, limiting the ability to map full network structures, from recruiters and facilitators to financial intermediaries and digital infrastructure. U.S. responses are therefore often reactive, targeting individual actors instead of disrupting entire systems early.

3. Overseas Networks Require Intelligence-Led Disruption

A significant share of cyber-enabled trafficking activity occurs outside the U.S., especially in regions where enforcement is weak. Cases involving Southeast Asian scam compounds show how traffickers exploit weak governance to sustain large-scale operations.

Domestic law enforcement actions alone are not sufficient to address these networks. Effective disruption requires intelligence-led approaches that combine foreign intelligence collection, coordination with international partners, and targeted action against digital infrastructure, facilitators, and financial flows abroad.

At the same time, human trafficking is not consistently treated as a cyber-related national security threat. This limits the use of existing cyber capabilities that could be applied to disrupt trafficking systems. As trafficking becomes more digital, this gap reduces the effectiveness of the current U.S. intelligence strategy.

RECOMMENDATION

1. **Designate Cyber-Enabled Human Trafficking as a Standing Intelligence Community Priority**

The Director of National Intelligence (DNI) should formally make cyber-enabled human trafficking a top priority within the Intelligence Community. This should integrate trafficking into existing cyber threat frameworks and require coordinated collection, analysis, and reporting across agencies.

Raising trafficking to this level would ensure it is treated like other cyber-enabled threats, improving visibility into network activity and enabling earlier detection of emerging patterns. It would also align resources and analytic focus across agencies that currently address trafficking in fragmented ways.

2. **Improve Integration of Cyber, Financial, and Trafficking Intelligence**

The Office of the Director of National Intelligence (ODNI) should strengthen integration across agencies by bringing together analysts from the National Security Agency, the Central Intelligence Agency, the U.S. Department of the Treasury, and the Federal Bureau of Investigation into joint teams focused on specific trafficking networks or issues. These analysts should work together with each agency contributing its expertise, including intelligence collection, financial tracking, and law enforcement support.

This effort should focus on integrating cyber intelligence, financial data, and trafficking indicators to map and disrupt networks. Intelligence on a trafficking network's digital operations should be shared across the team, allowing financial analysts to trace associated cryptocurrency transactions and identify key facilitators, while law enforcement partners use this information to support investigations or enforcement actions. Priority areas should include identifying online recruitment channels, tracking cryptocurrency transactions, and analyzing digital infrastructure used by traffickers.

Improved integration would reduce information silos, improve real-time coordination, and enable the Intelligence Community to move from fragmented insights to a more complete understanding of trafficking networks.

3. **Strengthen Intelligence Support for Financial and Overseas Network Disruption**

The ODNI should strengthen intelligence support to financial and operational efforts targeting trafficking networks, particularly those operating overseas. This includes improving information sharing with Treasury and law enforcement on cryptocurrency wallets, shell company networks, and cross-border payment systems linked to trafficking.

Additionally, ODNI should strengthen intelligence collection and coordination to support overseas disruption, including collaboration with partners and support for operations targeting trafficking hubs, such as scam centers and digital infrastructure providers. This includes aligning intelligence efforts with activities led by agencies such as the CIA and Treasury to enable targeted sanctions, enforcement actions, and partner government engagement.

Strengthening intelligence support in these areas would improve the U.S. ability to disrupt trafficking networks at their source rather than responding after harm has occurred.